

The Science Crusade

An award-winning researcher puts his all into reawakening a love for science in young minds



RAO TEACHES CHEMISTRY TO A GROUP OF STUDENTS

By Stephen David

It's a balmy, enervating morning as award-winning scientist Chintamani Nagesa Ramachandra Rao, 76, explains molecular structures to a group of young students. They are rivetted by Rao as they move around a 5-ft-tall molecular model in the basement of his education technology unit of the Post-Graduate Centre for Advanced Scientific and Advanced Research. Simply dressed, the older man speaks in English as well as Kannada for the students from nearby villages.

Talking science to school children is his mission—and Rao, one of the country's most respected and feted scientists, is enjoying every minute of this new class of complete greenhorns. The chairman of the Scientific Advisory Commission to the Prime Minister, Rao wants Indian children to embrace the sciences. Perturbed by the IT effect that has forced thousands of students to look at the software services sector as a viable career, Rao decided to invest money and time into luring them towards the basic sciences. "If children don't catch on to science at a young age, we will lose whatever scientific or technological advantage we have," says Rao. Though close to seven lakh undergraduates join engineering every year in India—

against 80,000 in the US—many move to the IT sector.

To put a stop to this trend, Rao has put a big chunk of the million-dollar 2005 Dan David Award from Tel Aviv University, Israel, into the CNR Rao Education Foundation. He stands next to a bronze bust of his guru, chemistry Nobel Laureate Linus Carl Pauling, and says, "Dream big, study hard and study science." He talks about Pauling, a two-time Nobel prize winner, who was 13 when his interest grew in chemistry. The teenager was fascinated by how "one substance is converted into another, or two substances react to produce a third substance".

Rao is certain that more scientists will emerge from India's villages than from its cities and this is where education needs a push. Rao's classes have had the desired effect. "He makes science seem so simple," says Class IX student C. Srikanth. They will, perhaps, realise later that the man simplifying science to them has made seminal contributions to chemical spectroscopy, molecular structures, surface chemistry, high temperature superconductivity and nano-technology. Rao also wants to see India lead in world sciences soon. From the signs of the times, he has come up with science for our times. ■